

Romans

Imputed Righteousness

Ch. 4

<https://tinyurl.com/RomeGospel>

The Grace of God Revealed

How *the* perfectly just LORD *has* forgiven sin...!

*“Blessed is he whose transgression is **forgiven**,
whose sin is **covered**,
Blessed is the man to whom
the **LORD** does **not impute iniquity**,
And in whose spirit there is **no deceit**.”*

• **Psalm 32:1-2; Romans 4:7-8**

*“...that **He might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus**.” Romans 3:26*

FIRST - Read Romans 3:21-26

THE QUESTION:

- How can a perfectly **just** God forgive sins?
- How can **sinful** man find favor with a **righteous** God?

THE ANALOGY:

- God (the Son) presides as the Judge of mankind (pagan, moral, and spiritual men). John 5:22
- The Son steps down from the Judgment seat and assumes the seat of the plaintiff (mankind). Isaiah 53:11
- The Son himself assumes the just penalty of sin for all of sinful mankind.
- The Father is satisfied with the just payment for sin.
- The Father demonstrates mercy by extending the righteousness of one man to cover many. 2 Cor. 5:21

God demonstrates His perfect justice at the same time that he demonstrates His perfect mercy... in the act of delivering justice, he also justifies.

Eph. 2:8 “For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, lest anyone should boast.

Hallelujah! What a Savior!

God justifies sinners by faith, not by works, and Abraham is the pattern for all who believe.

Topic	Common Protestant View	Restoration Theology Emphasis	Key Text
Nature of Faith	Faith = belief/trust alone	Faith = belief that responds in obedience	Rom. 1:5
Justification	By faith alone (no role of obedience)	By grace through faith that obeys	Rom. 3:28
Works	All "works" excluded	Works of law excluded; obedient faith included	Rom. 4:3
Baptism	Symbol after salvation	Part of union with Christ	Rom. 6:3-4
Righteousness	Imputed only (legal standing)	Imputed & lived out (transformation)	Rom. 6:18
Human Ability	Total inability without prior regeneration	Sinful but able to respond to the gospel	Rom. 10:17
Election	Often individual and unconditional	Often corporate / based in God's plan	Rom. 9:16
Assurance	Eternal security (cannot fall away)	Assurance + need to remain faithful	Rom. 11:22
Grace & Obedience	Sometimes separated	Grace produces obedience	Rom. 6:1-2
Law	Reveals sin, not binding	Same, but emphasis on Spirit-led life	Rom. 7:6
Christian Life	Ongoing struggle emphasized	Victory through the Spirit emphasized	Rom. 8:1-4
Unity & Liberty	Wide variation	Strong emphasis on unity, avoid binding opinions	Rom. 14:13

Doctrinal Comparison Chart - Key Areas of Debate

Discussion Reflection

How does Romans define faith?
 What is the role of obedience?
 How do grace and obedience work together?
 What does it mean to be "in Christ"?
 How should this shape how you live?

Two Ways of Understanding Salvation

Question	Protestant Emphasis	Restoration
Emphasis		
What saves?	Faith alone	Grace through
obedient faith		
When does salvation occur?	At belief	At
response to gospel (faith, repentance, baptism)		
What follows?	Obedience as evidence	
	Obedience as part of faith and ongoing life	

Two Ways of Understanding Salvation

Doctrinal Comparisons

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Key Balancing Truths in Romans

These help avoid extremes:

- **Faith and obedience belong together**
 - Romans 1:5 - "obedience of faith"
- **Grace does not allow sin**
 - Romans 6:1-2 - "Absolutely not!"
- **No condemnation in Christ**
 - Romans 8:1
- **But continue in God's kindness**
 - Romans 11:22

Two Paths in Romans

<u>Path</u>	<u>Description</u>	<u>Key Verses</u>
Man's Righteousness	Self-trust, works, law-keeping	
	Romans 10:3	
God's Righteousness	Grace, faith, Christ, new life	
	Romans 3:22	

Simple Summary

All agree: salvation is by grace

The main difference: **what faith includes**

Romans calls for:

- faith
- submission
- transformation
- perseverance

God's Character Revealed

The Promises to Abraham

Initiator of the Covenant

- **Genesis 12:1-3** God calls Abraham to leave his homeland, initiating the promise.
- God's promises are grounded in His initiative, not Abraham's worthiness.

Covenant Keeper

- **Genesis 15:1-6** God ratifies the covenant by passing between the pieces, showing He alone carries the responsibility of fulfillment.
- **Genesis 17:7** God calls it an "everlasting covenant."

Faithfulness Across Generations

- God reiterates His promise to Isaac (**Genesis 26:3-4**) and Jacob (**Genesis 28:13-15**).
- God's character is revealed in His unilateral commitment to Abraham; He binds Himself to His promises with no possibility of failure.
- **Romans 1:17** *For the righteousness of God is revealed in the gospel from faith to faith, just as it is written, "The righteous by faith will live."*

God's Character in the Promise to Abraham

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Faithfulness Across Generations

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Teaching Point: God's character is revealed in His unilateral commitment to Abraham - He binds Himself to His promises with no possibility of failure.

Overview: God's covenant with Abraham (land, descendants, blessing) sets the redemptive trajectory.

Teaching Notes:

Genesis 12:1-3 → Call and promise.

Genesis 15 → Covenant ratified by God alone.

Galatians 3:7-9 → Fulfilled in Christ for all nations.

Cross-References: Romans 4:20-21; Hebrews 11:8-12.

Discussion Guidance: Highlight Abraham's faith response; How did Abraham's respond?

READ: Romans 4:20–21; Hebrews 11:8–12.

God's Character Revealed in Christ

Abraham's Seed

Jesus, the Fulfillment of the Promise

- **Galatians 3:16** The promises were ultimately to Abraham's "seed," Christ.
- **Luke 3:34** Jesus is in Abraham's line, the heir of the covenant.

Blessing to the Nations

- **Galatians 3:8** The gospel was announced beforehand to Abraham: all nations blessed in Christ.
- **Matthew 28:19** Fulfillment in the Great Commission to the nations.

Faith as the Response

- **Romans 4:20-21** Abraham's faith in God's promise models how we trust in Christ.

Observation

- The covenant blessing reaches its fulfillment in *Jesus Christ, who brings salvation to every nation.*

God's Character Revealed in Christ (Abraham's Seed)

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Discussion Questions

Why did God's promise to Abraham matter so much in the biblical storyline?

How does Abraham's faith model the way we are to trust God today?

In what ways are you personally living as an heir of Abraham's promise?

How does this covenant shape our mission to bless the nations?

References to the Promise of Abraham

In the NT – Promise Quoted or Paraphrased

Luke 1:54-55 Mary's *Magnificat* praises God for remembering His promise to Abraham and his offspring.

Luke 1:68-73 Zechariah rejoices that God has "remembered His holy covenant, the oath that He swore to Abraham."

Acts 3:25 Peter cites Genesis 12:3: "*In your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed.*"

Acts 7:2-8 Stephen recounts the covenant with Abraham, including the promise of land and descendants.

Romans 4:3 Paul quotes Genesis 15:6: "*Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness.*"

Romans 4:17-18 References God's word in Genesis 17:5, "*I have made you the father of many nations.*"

Galatians 3:6-9 Cites Genesis 15:6 and 12:3 to show that the gospel was proclaimed beforehand to Abraham.

Galatians 3:16 Interprets "seed/offspring" in Genesis 12:7 as singular—fulfilled in Christ.

Hebrews 6:13-15 Mentions God swearing by Himself when He promised to bless and multiply Abraham (Genesis 22:16-17).

Hebrews 11:8-12, 17-19 Recounts Abraham's faith in God's promise of land, descendants, and resurrection hope.

James 2:21-23 Quotes Genesis 15:6, showing faith and works united in Abraham's obedience.

These passages explicitly **quote or allude** to God's words in Genesis 12:1-3, 15:5-6, or 17:7.

Theology of the Promise

John 8:39-40, 56 *Jesus claims Abraham rejoiced to see His day, revealing Abraham's faith in the coming Messiah.*

Romans 4:9-25 *Paul argues that Abraham was justified by faith before circumcision, making him the father of all who believe.*

Romans 9:6-8 *"Not all who are descended from Israel belong to Israel"; true children of Abraham are those of the promise.*

Galatians 3:14, 29 *Believers in Christ receive the blessing of Abraham; the Spirit and inclusion as heirs.*

Galatians 4:21-31 *The allegory of Sarah and Hagar contrasts promise vs. law.*

Ephesians 2:11-19 *Gentiles are brought near and made fellow citizens, heirs of the promises once given to Israel.*

Hebrews 11:13-16 *Abraham looked for a heavenly city, showing the spiritual dimension of the promise.*

Hebrews 13:20 *Refers to the eternal covenant that fulfills God's promises through Christ's blood.*

The Promise Interpreted Theologically

These passages **explain the covenant's fulfillment in Christ and believers.**

Promise Extended to the Nations

Abraham's Blessing & the Global Mission of the Church

Matthew 8:11-12 Jesus says many from east and west will *recline with Abraham in the kingdom*.

Luke 13:28-29 Echoes the same image of *Gentiles included with the patriarchs*.

Acts 13:32-33 Paul calls the *resurrection* “the good news that God promised to the fathers.”

Romans 15:8-12 Paul teaches that *Christ confirmed the promises to the patriarchs so the Gentiles might glorify God*.

Galatians 3:7-9 *Those of faith are blessed along with Abraham, the man of faith*.

Galatians 3:28-29 In Christ, all are one; Jew, Greek, slave, free, male, female; and *heirs according to promise*.

Ephesians 3:6 Gentiles are “*fellow heirs, members of the same body, and partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel*.”

The Promise Extended to the Nations

These passages **apply Abraham's blessing to the global mission of the church**.

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Promise as our Destiny in Hope

Our Final Inheritance and Eternal Life

Romans 4:13 Abraham and his offspring receive “*the promise that he would be heir of the world.*”

Hebrews 6:18-20 The hope set before us is anchored in *God’s unchangeable promise to Abraham.*

Hebrews 11:39-40 The faithful, including Abraham, did not receive the promise in full, *anticipating perfection in Christ.*

2 Peter 3:13 The ultimate inheritance of the new heavens and new earth fulfills the faith of Abraham, the “*heir of the world.*”

The Promise as Eschatological Hope

These passages **tie Abraham’s promise to final inheritance and eternal life.**

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Summary Application Points

Trust God’s Promises: Identify one area in life that feels impossible (like Abraham’s childlessness) and bring it before God in faith.

Embrace Identity: Reflect on Galatians 3:29 - “If you are Christ’s, then you are Abraham’s offspring, heirs according to promise.”

Be a Blessing: Look for one practical way to bless someone outside your immediate circle (an unbeliever, a neighbor, someone from another culture).

Global Vision: Pray for one nation each day to receive the blessing of the gospel.

Encouraging Self-Reflection

Questions for the “Just Man” of Romans 4

Focus: Faith as the channel through which we are made right with God, illustrated by Abraham and fulfilled in Christ.

- “You trust that God keeps His promises, as Abraham did. Why would you believe that God is both faithful and true unless He has revealed Himself as unchanging, trustworthy, and righteous?”
- “Your faith points beyond your own goodness to something greater. If your moral efforts are never perfect, on what basis can you stand before a holy God, if not on the righteousness He provides by faith?”
- “Consider Abraham: he trusted God’s word before it was fulfilled. Has God’s faithfulness to Abraham and to countless believers since not shown that He is real and that we can be certain of His character?”
- “When you put your faith in Jesus Christ as the Just One, how does this confirm for you that God has revealed Himself in history, both through His written word and through the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus?”